

comforts: after all, generations of Rathores, Jodhpur's royals, had been educated in Eton and Oxbridge. What very few people knew, however, was the real source of Lanchester's architectural inspiration.

It was a visiting American historian and an expert on Hindu and Buddhist thought, Fred R. Holmes, who casually met Babji and informed him that the palace was essentially a Hindu structure incorporating Buddhist structural techniques and that the Hindu symbolism had been derived from Angkor Wat! That chance encounter is also the inspiration for this book.

Babji asked historian-hotelier Aman Nath—whose earlier book, incidentally, was on Rashtrapati Bhawan—to oversee the final product but the intimate details about the palace, those involved in its conception, the materials used, the detailing, the actual construction itself and the royal backdrop is the scholarly work of Holmes and his wife, Ann Newton Holmes, who is also an expert on Rajput buildings.

This is the first book on one of India's princely palaces and while Umaid Bhawan may not, arguably, be the maharaja of palaces, it certainly is among the grandest. The story of its conception and construction is a fascinating one as is the historical backdrop against which it was built. There are interesting little vignettes—the importance of numerology in the construction and design, especially the number nine, the extensive use of Hindu mythology in the murals and carvings, the influence of Vaastu shashtra and the innovative techniques used for transporting material and for cooling the palace to withstand the fierce desert heat and dust.

The book is also embellished with some stunning photographs from the royal archives as well as those of the present day palace and the Art Deco murals and paintings by a resident Polish artist of the time, taken by well-known photographer Amit Pasricha. Today, much of the palace and the private quarters of Gaj Singh and his family lie hidden behind the façade and priorities of a five-star hotel. What this book offers is an invaluable insight into royal dreams and the fierce competition among Indian maharajas for architectural ambition. ■

Food for Angst

A racy chronicle of the global food system, ranging from how we farm to how we eat and the impact on our health and economies



STUFFED AND STARVED: WHAT LIES BENEATH THE WORLD FOOD CRISIS

by RAJ PATEL

Harper Litmus

Price: Rs 495; Pages: 438

■ **By Shankkar Aiyar**

You would think books are meant to entertain, inspire, inform and empower, besides functioning as décor in some homes. New writing, though, has spawned hybrids that ostensibly aim to inform and empower but are designed to fuel angst. Raj Patel's *Stuffed and Starved* is for those looking for a cause and an angst to feed. Patel has chosen to study the business of food, rather than the issue of food and the business built

only 13 per cent is arable) and the rising demand for food, thanks to rising population. Since 1900, world population has shot up from 1.5 billion to over 6.6 billion now. With 80 million added every year, global population could touch nine billion. Which essentially means more food will be required. Anglo Saxon theorists believe making land yield more using technology helps bridge the chasm between limited land and rising demand. Patel disagrees: "Unless you are a corporate food executive, the food system is not working for you." Yes, there is much aggravation due to unfair pricing in global marts as argued in the WTO and there is criminal wastage. Studies by University of Arizona claim 27



HEMANT CHAWLA

BIG BITE: Lopsided policies harm both consumers and producers

around it. Eminently qualified with degrees from Oxford, LSE and Cornell, armed with an exposure to World Bank policies and trade wars at WTO, Patel has created a mosaic of facts and conjecture to analyse, nay critique the food economy

Prima facie, the world food economy is based on a complex matrix of finite resources, changing needs, evolving tastes, demand-driven pricing, rising population and disparate systems. The issue is trapped between the finite availability of 148.94 million sq km of land (of which

million tonne of food worth \$30 billion (Rs 1,35,000 crore) is wasted just in the US. Anecdotal evidence of food riots, spiralling prices, misplaced faith in biofuel suggests that there is something rotten in the system. But is it all rotten and wrong? You may argue with the assumptions and ques-

tion the conclusions, but Patel is convinced and writes with the zeal of an evangelist to harvest agnostic souls. Sample this: "The current food system is a wasteland. The case against it extends beyond the harm it causes to people and systematic cruelty to animals. It demands unsustainable levels of energy and water use. It contributes to global warming and provides fertile ground for disease. It limits our sensuousness and compassion."

Almost a travelogue, the book rants and races through issues ranging from the rights of women to farmer suicides in India. If angst whets your appetite, read on. ■